



Bryce 5.5

Creating 3D imagery wasn't easy, we thought—until we discovered a software called Bryce

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Rendering 3D images is a wonderful and addictive passion as well as an attractive career option. But some people—for example, graphic artists—are actually afraid of 3D rendering software, and their fears are well-founded many a time; seldom will you find a software that's easy to learn and master. Here, we'll introduce you to one software that is!

Bryce 5.5 is a 3D illustration and rendering software available for free download (122 MB) from www.daz3d.com. (You'll also find it on our August 2007 DVD.) You'll need to create an account at the site to procure your free serial code.

The beauty of Bryce is the ease with which you can create breathtakingly realistic 3D landscapes and animations using a drag-and-drop interface on a "real-time canvas" (meaning you can alter the position and shape, and even replace objects in the scene any time you want). All this in an intuitive manner, in a matter of minutes. You design a scene in 3D within Bryce, then Bryce takes the 3D information and figures how it would look in 2D (with shading and all) so when you render it, it looks like a painting with a 3D effect.

Let's look at how handy this tool really is.



Yes, you can actually create this in Bryce—with considerable ease!

Easy-to-use GUI Toolbars

You'll see three types of toolbars: one for creating objects, one for editing them, and one for editing the environment ("Sky & Fog"). There is also a camera control section that allows you to change the camera angle or your view of the scene (refer image below). The mountain in the image—with the objects around it—changes your camera view to top, then front, left, right, back, and underneath. Clicking on the small ring at the upper right corner gives you a "flyaround" preview of your creation,

meaning you can look at the whole scene at once. You can either move the camera angle on any of the three axes by clicking and dragging on the flat arrows, or you can move all three at once with the trackball—though this is a bit harder in terms of ease of control. Just below the trackball are the render options, with the render button at the centre. The rest of the options allow you to do such things as turning textures on and off while rendering, doing a quick preview render, resuming rendering, and clearing a render.

At the very top of the screenshot alongside (Camera controls and Nano Preview) is the Nano Preview window, which gives you a preview, in quick thumbnail size render form, of your creation. This saves time because full-screen rendering takes much longer. You can save camera angles by clicking on the little buttons to the left of the window. The top button gives you the default camera angle.



The section where you control the camera angle—and more

The Create Toolbar

The Create Toolbar is the one which you will be using the most while using this software. The first three of these icons represent infinite planes; the blue one is water, the white one is clouds, and the last is a ground plane.

Next is the mountain, which allows you to create random mountains, and there's a tool that allows you to edit almost everything about the mountain. Similarly, there is the random rock, symmetrical lattice, and a multitude of objects (in blue) that can be placed in the manipulation field (the 3D canvas). The last group of objects (in yellow) are the light sources; these let you place spotlights, radial light sources, parallel lights, etc. and decide their directions to illuminate the



The "Create" section using which you can place different objects in the scene

scene. Clicking on the icons places them in the manipulation field.

As you probably know, proper lighting can make all the difference between just another illustration and a masterpiece.

The Edit Toolbar

This toolbar allows you to edit the objects you just created. The tool on the far left is the material editor, which opens up a window where you can choose from or create custom textures for your objects. Next is the stretch tool, which allows, as the name suggests, to stretch objects on the three axes. This can also be used to mirror objects. The rotation tool and the move tool are obvious. The align tool that comes next lets you line up all your objects in refer-



The "Edit" section where you can edit the objects placed in the scene

ence to one thing or another. Next is the randomise tool, which sends your objects scurrying in random directions... Last comes the terrain editor tool, which brings up different edit windows for rocks, mountains, light sources, and more. You can also edit objects in the manipulation window using the mouse.

The Sky & Fog Toolbar



The great outdoors... create the environment of your choice

This toolbar allows you to create custom skies and atmospheres for your scene. Each of the controls has a slider using which image attributes can be controlled. The control on the far left selects the sky mode and sky colour. The second control selects shadows and ambient colour. The third modifies haze amount and colour, and the fourth modifies fog and fog colour. Experiment with the others...

The next tool is the cloud frequency, which is used to randomly place clouds in the scene. By clicking and dragging your mouse over this field, you can alter the position of the sun. Clicking on the small sphere at the top left of this sphere will toggle